How to make

(something) **Alternative**

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hattiesburg-alt.neocities.org

The first step

Let's say you took a trip somewhere to a different community in a different city and saw an unusual band or went to a unique art show and thought to yourself, "wow, I wish we had that here." I have to tell you; you've already taken the first step in creating something alternative.

Maybe you have a good idea about wanting to start something really cool that you haven't seen before. Something whimsical or beautiful or groundbreaking. These too are good reasons to try to do something alternative.

Hattiesburg Alternative

For me, this something was zines, and when I arrived in Hattiesburg, it became Hattiesburg Alternative.

A zine is any sort of printed booklet, self-published and typically about a single topic by a single author and can cover any subject from art, music, and culture to political topics and social justice or any special interests like DIY hobbies, the sciences, history, and theories.

For me, my interests spanned from music, art, poetry, prose, social justice, local community, and international trends. I wanted to highlight local artists, writers, and musicians and provide a platform for them to be presented next to each other in a way in which we supported each other and created credibility for everyone in the zine. Perhaps somewhat selfishly, I also wanted to force myself out of isolation and into a cooperative environment with creative artists that benefited the local community and whom I admired.

These interests culminated in a recurring zine that features poetry, prose, photography, sketches and paintings from artists local to Hattiesburg but also occasionally from outside the city. It also features interviews with bands, instructors in the creative arts, community leaders, or people with similar interests as well as editorial pieces on books, music reviews and recommendations, event documentation,

and finally, a reflection on current social justice issues and their connection to the arts.

If you want to read issues of Hattiesburg Alternative, go to hattiesburg-alt.neocities.org.

Something Alternative

This zine is to help you recreate what I did with Hattiesburg Alternative. It's my sincere hope that you find some knowledge here that you find useful and create a similar zine that could be called (wherever you are) Alternative. If you're in Oak Grove, I hope you make Oak Grove Alternative. If you're at USM, I hope you make USM Alternative. If you're in Gautier, I hope you make Gautier Alternative. If you're at the bottom of the ocean, I hope you're at least wearing a swimsuit.

Making something alternative will take you from passive observer to active participant and it will give you both purpose and voice. It's not always easy, but it shouldn't be too hard. It's ok to go at your own pace, just make sure you're doing it for you and your community and you're not doing anything you don't want to do.

Even if you don't want to make a (something) Alternative zine, I think you will find many things that are helpful if you want to make a submissions-based project.

Before I get too deep into the how-to section of this zine, I want to talk about framework. A framework in this context is how your (something) Alternative zine practices your project's ethos. In using a framework, I'm able to pull inspiration from a variety of sources (literary journals, online blogs, art magazines) and reframe the material so it looks and functions differently.

The framework I follow is called Do It Yourself or DIY. It's also becoming known as Do It Ourselves or DIO as we try to come together more often for a common goal. DIY comes from or is at least adjacent to the punk scene and anarchist movement, and although punk and anarchy comes with a certain aesthetic and attitude, those

aren't necessarily core beliefs or ethos of DIY. If you want to read a little more about what I believe DIY is, check out another zine, *DIY: an Earnest Appeal.* It's on the website provided earlier.

In DIY, some of these core beliefs are:

- Anti-racism and anti-authoritarianism – DIY actively counters the racism and fascism that curses our country and society.
- Non-commercial – DIY should be either free or be raising funds for a good cause. The pursuit of profit hampers accessibility and influences content for popular consumption.
- Informational – DIY should be practical and specialized to assist with self-reliance and to counter misinformation.
- Community-centric – DIY forms bonds with like-minded individuals and contributes toward mutual aid to all those in need. It encourages cooperation beyond social norms.

So, now applying this ethos to your (something) Alternative zine,

Anti-racist

We're not going to include any racist, prejudiced, queerphobic, or otherwise targeted material aimed at putting down minority or vulnerable groups. You don't need to put a ton of time and effort into vetting people, just stop it when you see it.

Personally, I don't include any mean-spirited or aimlessly violent work either. If the work has a point or good reason for how it is, that's different. However, you don't have to include anything that doesn't sit right with you, but it's good to know why you won't accept something in case you feel the need to provide a reason.

Anti-authoritarian

I also don't include work that appeals to the establishment. This is an alternative zine, meant to build a platform for those who deserve it and don't otherwise have it, to challenge authority, to speak to those who are suffering, and to encourage dissent.

Non-commercial

Some people sell their zines, and that's fine. Like I said earlier, I don't think we should be spending a lot of time and effort vetting or scrutinizing our peers. Some zines also print ads, that too is ok, depending on the types of ads. Personally, I'd rather it be free for the reader. However, I think adding anything blatantly income driven changes the nature of the zine. It doesn't make it unforgivable or unacceptable; it just changes it from a community-centered project to another for-profit product.

And maybe income is something your zine needs to function as intended. Just realize you have a choice: to change the functionality of the zine to minimize the cost to an acceptable charitable loss or to start a business venture.

Informational

If you're able to leave your reader realizing they've learned more about the world, or themselves, or the strength of community for instance, you've just done an amazing thing. There's a lot of zines out there that are an entertaining breath of fresh air, and those are important too. But to instill knowledge and to contribute to an understanding of a movement is powerful, and if you have the opportunity to do that, just take it.

Community-centric

Don't forget why you are starting this zine. It's not for your ego or to build your reputation. It's not to generate income or to even make it in the arts. It's for the community. It's to bring about renewed joy, wisdom, and resistance to your community so that you and everyone around you can live better in it together.

Actually doing it

A final tenant of DIY is actually doing the project. Whether that's music, art, or a publication like this one, Doing It Yourself prioritizes completion of the project over anything else. That's not to say that you're not being careful, thoughtful, or fact-checking. It just means that you're doing the best you practically can with the time, information, skills, and resources at your disposal. Try your best not to

get stuck on a singular aspect and try something else, move on, or just release it even if you're not totally happy with the end result. Creating "bad" and "cringe" projects is a canon part of becoming better.

When I first began doing things myself, I didn't have a good understanding of DIY, and certainly the people in my circle didn't either. I remember that many of my peers were especially bad about pushing down projects that appealed directly to a base rather than established gatekeepers and methodologies. Try not to weigh yourself down with the standards, funding, or social networks others expect for the type of project you're doing.

DIY is about redefining success and is a rejection of professionalism for the good of yourself and the community. Practicing DIY is accepting that you and your friend group are the best people to do it yourselves because it was your idea, and your art or yall's project needs to genuinely reflect yourselves as the people behind it. Never use AI and leave room for your project to reflect your tastes, ethics, and even bias as you best see fit. So, push an agenda! And as long as you're following the ethos of DIY, it will resonate with your peers.

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ok. Sorry for making you read all of that. I just think it's really important. For this next section, it might be helpful to go to the website, hattiesburg-alt.neocities.org to view an issue or follow along with a printed copy.

How to make a (something) Alternative zine

The first thing I do is gather around a dozen submissions for original visual art (sketches, drawings, paintings, photography) and literature (poetry and short prose). For the first few issues, I reached out or approached these artists or writers directly and asked for a submission. If you approach people to ask for submissions, I recommending going up to artists or writers who you genuinely like and connect with rather than approaching someone because of their local fame or even the quality of their art or writing.

Later as my reputation and social media presence grew, I'd release a "Call for Artists", and people would just email me submissions, and I could go from there. I like to be very accepting of submissions, and as I mentioned earlier, we're not going to include any racist, prejudiced, queerphobic, or otherwise targeted material aimed at putting down minority or vulnerable groups. Personally, I don't publish anything that aimlessly violent (we don't publish direct action on something this visible) or just anything that doesn't sit right with me. Sometimes I feel tempted to reject something just because I don't personally like it, but those pieces always seem to be the ones people come up to me and say they really connect with. And I don't want to take that away.

While I'm finishing up submissions, I'm thinking about what else should go in the zine. Whether that's interviews, show or album reviews, recommendations, reflective editorials, or a social justice or current events section, everything should tie back in with the arts and cultural aspects of the community. Think of these sections also as your chance to bind contributors together and connect them to a larger community.

The rest of the zine is about the sections I've put together to fill out the rest of the zine. You can recreate them, adjust them, or come up with entirely new ideas. It's all up to you and if you're trying to write something up about a topic and it's just not working out, try something different or save it to try again later.

Interviews

When I'm trying to decide who to interview, I think about anyone who has had success in the artistic community and who would have something informative to share about it. It can be a known artist, educator, active community member, event booker, or anyone who's for the community that has something interesting or insightful to say. Ask them maybe 4 or 5 questions about what they do, how they do it, how it interacts with the community, and maybe one fun question about themselves.

Reach out to the person you want to interview by whichever method (instagram, email, phone) you have access to and tell them that you

want to interview them and the zine that it's for. Then if they accept, write some questions and you can either meet up with them in person or send them the questions through one of those platforms. If you meet up in person, you can record the interview on your phone (just let them know you're recording) and use voice to text. Just proofread that text over and over to check for spelling mistakes and grammatical errors. If you send them the questions, it's just a matter of pasting their responses in your zine. Also don't bother transcribing or proofing sections you're not going to use.

I usually write a short bio about what they do in relation to the subject of the questions and note some of their other projects or contributions. You can also have them provide a bio or use one they already have as a go-by.

<u>You Should go to the Show!</u>

This is a quick show report about a recent local music show I went to, took some pictures of, and wrote a short summary on. You should include details like where it was, when it happened, and who played. You can also include anything interesting that happened, what you thought of each of the bands, and how you thought they performed.

<u>New Local Releases</u>

These are short reviews mainly for local music releases (singles, eps, or albums) but also include local chapbooks, other zines, music videos, video documentaries, and anything similar released by local creators. I always keep these super positive and as complimentary as possible without being dishonest.

<u>Recommendations</u>

These are media recommendations and can include art, books, movies, albums, playlists, etc. generally from outside of the local community. It can include anything that you enjoyed and made some sort of influence or impact on you or whoever is writing the article. Write about what you found special about the work and why you think people should enjoy it.

Upcoming events

This was just an upcoming event list. Honestly, I got tired of constantly updating this when I would reprint zines, so I only did it for the first issue. Things got a lot easier when hattiesburg.askapunk.net launched, and I could just reference that.

We're trying this again though for Fall 2026 with a new format and look and more details about the upcoming shows.

Scene News

This is a new one we're trying for Fall 2026. It's basically a scene report about new things happening in the music and creative scenes, specially projects (bands, groups, venues) that are starting, closing, or adjusting in any way or just anything happening that we think people would find interesting.

Visitor's Log

I'm not sure what we're even going to call this but it's also new for Fall 2026. We're asking a few touring bands to write a little about what it was like playing in Hattiesburg, what they appreciated, and what they find special about our community.

Final Thoughts

This is a very important section for me, so I always put it last. It's one or two pages about connecting the arts and creative community to the larger community and how we're inherently tied to our country's politics. This is something of a last chance to come out and stand for something and plainly state the bare minimum we expect and deserve as people and creatives. It's about acknowledging that some things are bigger than us, our work, and even our local community. And it's basic things like freedom, dignity, and justice and addressing the times these are neglected.

I try to write about these topics for a wide audience, highlighting the pain of the oppressed and our responsibility to make a better community for us all. I write plainly and directly about what's happening currently in our time, ICE raids, Palestinian genocide, and

the pitfalls and injustice of assimilation, capitalism, white-supremacy, hetero-normativity, and America-first beliefs.

To my relief, I've never had a featured artist withdraw from the zine because of any stance I take in this section, even though I ask them to review it before release.

I've stopped short of endorsing any political group or candidate. I don't know if this is the best policy to take and I may be recommending some in the Fall 2026 issue. Honestly, it's taken some time for me to find the groups I want to be a part of but I've been finding a few (a workers union, United Campus Workers and the Democratic Socialists of America which is opening a chapter that includes Hattiesburg) and have been working with them recently.

As with everything in this zine and DIY, it's important to stay flexible and adjust to changes and threats to the community as they appear.

Formatting

How you format your zine is completely up to you but choose a style that suits you and the content of the zine. Punk zines have bold text and chaotic element placement. Academic-style zines have a minimalist, uniform, and straightforward presentation. Artsy zines can be very maximalist with lots of detail and very little empty space. Feel free to take inspiration from many sources or create your own style.

I format using Microsoft Word, just because I have free access to it and I'm very familiar with it. Another good software choice is LibreOffice, which is free and similar to Microsoft Office. You can also use Google or Proton Docs. Personally, I don't use Canva often and you may find that some folks in DIY consider it a little overused or generic but use whatever works for you. As long as it's not AI.

You don't actually need to use software to format your zine if you don't want to or if you don't have access to any. Traditionally, DIYers would print out the elements of each page, cut them out, and paste them on a background page, almost like a collage. Then you can scan them into your computer and print out the zine from that file or copy

each time. As a nod to this, I did this for the covers of issues three, four, and five.

Zines can be all sort of shapes and sizes, but the most common one is on standard 8.5" x 11" printer paper where it comes out landscape orientation and folded and stapled down the center. It's common for zines to be in black and white.

For a detailed explanation on page layout, check out: https://the-counterforce.org/flip-on-short-edge-how-to-print-zines-for-distribution/

Communication

How you communicate throughout this process can make or break your (something) Alternative zine. Be humble, kind, positive, but most importantly be clear. Tell people what you're looking for and what you want from them when including them in whatever capacity. Be considerate of their time, art, and contributions to the community. For most creatives, their projects are personal and passionate, so be gentle with them. Avoid pointless or destructive conflict and try to make up with someone when you've offended them.

Release Form

Before I publish anyone's submitted work, I have them sign a release form, which details exactly what they're allowing me to do with their work, and now includes four things: reproduction of their work in the printed and online zine, permission to use their name as specified for artistic credit (some people don't want to use their name or give a pen name), digital storage on my PC (so I can print it), and for Fall 2026, allowing me to share the digital file of the zine so that people can print it themselves.

This form does not only gives you the legal protection and ability to make the zine, it also clearly communicates what's happening to artists' work and what they're consenting to by being in the zine.

If you want a copy of this form to use as a go-by you can email me at dwgoldsmith3@proton.me

Errors and typos

If you think you noticed a typo or some sort of error in someone's work, just ask them if that's what they meant to do. I never adjust anything about someone's submission without at least asking, and I only ask if I think they may have made a spelling mistake or something unintentional. It's not our place to question artistic choices, and it's best to present the work as the artist intended.

Final Approval

One thing I do, that I somehow haven't seen replicated, is to send back the publication to artists and contributors before releasing it to the public. This is to correct any mistakes that I have made on my end, like the formatting of their work, misspelling their name or contact, or any miscredits. It's also to make sure the artists or contributors accept their work being represented next to everything else in the zine. If you don't hear back for too long (a week) you can go ahead and publish.

Luckily, I've never had anyone back out at this point, but if someone wants out, just let them. The zine can be shorter or can include any doodles or whatever you want to fill the space with.

The Follow-up

It's always a nice thing to follow back up with everyone in the zine and to make sure they all get a copy. Doing nice little things like this just goes a long way. It takes a little confidence and consideration but it's certainly a best practice.

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Making a (something) Alternative zine is just one way you can support your local community. What's important is that we're contributing in some way and in some capacity to build culture, speak out, practice independence and free-thought, and to support each other and make inter-personal connections.